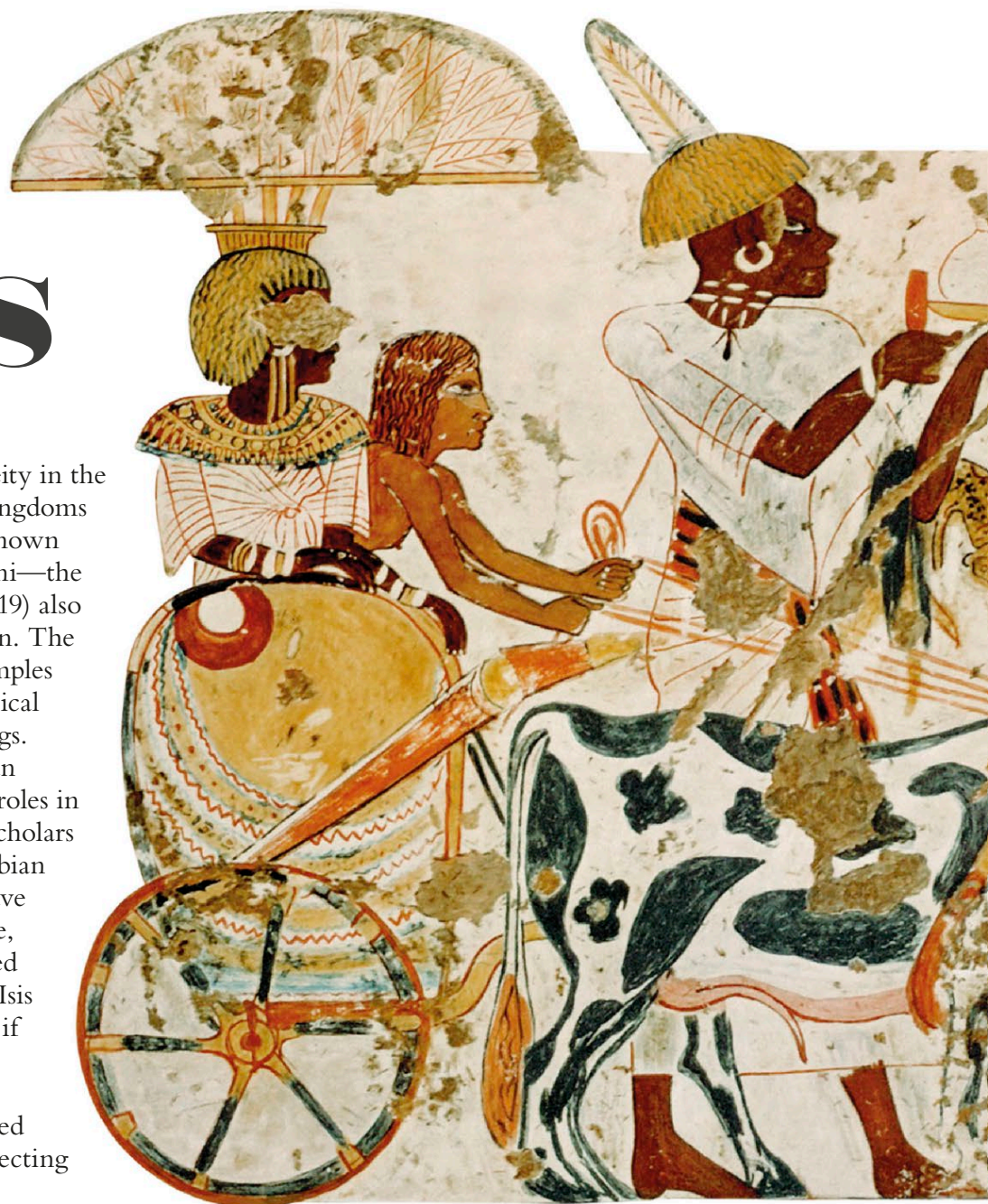


WARRIOR queens

ANCIENT AFRICAN KINGDOMS



▼ Status symbol

The jewelry found in Queen Amanishakheto's pyramid, such as this ornate gold armlet, testifies to the wealth and status of Nubian queens. Worn by Amanishakheto in the 1st century BCE, the armlet is decorated with a depiction of the winged goddess, Mut.



While the dominant deity in the sub-Saharan Nubian kingdoms was the god Amun—known to the Nubians as Amani—the goddess Isis (see pp. 18–19) also inspired great dedication. The Nubians built many temples solely for this mythological mother and wife of kings. Her cult enabled Nubian women to take on key roles in the priesthood. Many scholars have suggested that Nubian royal succession may have followed the female line, and some have attributed this to the influence of Isis in ancient Africa. Even if succession was not matrilineal, evidence shows that women played an important role in selecting the next ruler.

Queens of Kush

The Nubian empire of Kush, located on the western banks of the Nile in modern-day Sudan, emerged around 1000 BCE. By 300 BCE, the capital had moved to Meroë,

ushering in a period of strong female rulers. While a king's mother and sisters were given the title of *kandake*, women who ruled in their own right were called *qore* (meaning “king”). One such *qore* was Shanakdakhete, who ruled in the late second century BCE. Her husband was regarded as her consort, rather than as a coruler. The Nubian queens were as formidable as kings: they fought wars, founded temples, and built monuments. Some presided over the most prosperous periods in Nubian history. Even a *kandake* could be fierce; relief carvings at the Temple of Apedamak at Naga show the Kandake Amanitore dressed for battle.

10
sovereign
queens ruled
Kush from
300 BCE to 200 CE